

Week 25: Evil

BIG IDEA

Evil is not a force God created; it is the absence of good, as darkness is the absence of light — the result of humanity's free choice to remove God since the garden. Philosophically, evil's very existence suggests God exists, because without good there is no standard for calling anything evil.

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- Pray deliberately for yourself, your students, and your leaders; these next weeks dive into deep, heavy things and may surface real pain and doubts.
- The coming weeks take two approaches to evil — philosophical (academic) and pastoral — so be patient; not every student responds to both.
- Evil is not something God created; it is the absence or privation of good, like darkness is absence of light and cold of heat.
- Since the garden, humanity chose to remove God and go its own way; God graciously allows free will, and evil resulted from that choice.
- Use a storyteller about being lost: a compass only works by pointing to something external; God serves as that external moral compass.
- Small group will get real fast: expect 'why does God allow suffering?'; table questions carefully, write them down, and pose them yourself if needed.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why does God allow suffering, and why do bad things happen to good people?
2. If evil is the absence of good rather than a created thing, how does that change how you think about it?
3. How does the very existence of evil actually suggest that God exists?
4. What happens when we make ourselves our own moral compass instead of orienting to something external?

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